Till the early twentieth century, it was believed that India was inhabited by aboriginal stone-age tribes till around 1500 BC when Indo-Europeans called ‘Aryans’ invaded the subcontinent from Central Asia with horses and iron weapons. Indian civilization was seen as a direct result of this invasion. Although the date was entirely arbitrary and not backed by any textual or archaeological evidence, this theory appeared to fit the pattern of later Central Asian invasions as well as explain certain linguistic similarities between Indian and European languages. Most importantly, it was politically convenient at that time as it painted the British as merely latter-day Aryans with a mission to civilize the natives.

This theory, however, had to be drastically revised when remains of the sophisticated Harappan civilization were discovered. They proved that Indian civilization clearly predated 1500 BC. Oddly, the ‘Aryan invasion theory’ was not thrown away. It was now argued that a people called the Dravidians (supposed ancestors of modern-day Tamils) created the Indus cities and that these cities were destroyed by the invading Aryans. This theory too ran into trouble. There is virtually no archaeological or literary evidence of such a large-scale invasion. As we shall see, the Harappan cities did not suddenly collapse but suffered a slow decline as a key river dried up and environmental conditions deteriorated.

Just by looking around, it will be obvious to anyone that India is home to a bewildering array of castes, tribes and language groups. Some of these groups came to India in historical times—Jews, Parsis, Ahoms, Turks to name a few. However, there are also many populations that have lived in the country for a very long time. Further complicating the picture is the fact that there has been a great deal of internal migration over thousands of years. So, where a group is found today may be very different from where it originated. Over the centuries most groups have mingled and yet a few have retained their unique identity to this day. In isolated pockets such as in the Andaman and Nicobar islands and in the North-Eastern states there are still tribes that have remained separate from the mainstream since prehistoric times.